

O P P O S I T I O N R E S E A R C H R E P O R T

Data Center Opposition Network

Organizations, Individuals, Funding Sources & Counter-Messaging Strategy

With Emphasis on the Texas Theater of Operations

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For Internal Strategy Use Only

Executive Summary

A well-funded, professionally organized network of national nonprofits, progressive foundations, and local grassroots groups is actively opposing data center development across the United States. This opposition has already blocked or delayed \$64 billion in projects across 24 states, with 142 identified activist groups. Texas is emerging as the next major battleground.

This report identifies the key organizations, their primary arguments, their funding sources, and — critically — provides recommended responses and retorts for each major line of opposition. The goal is to equip data center developers, economic development authorities, and their advocates with evidence-based counter-messaging.

Key Findings at a Glance

The Scale: \$18 billion in data center projects have been fully blocked and another \$46 billion delayed over the last two years, according to Data Center Watch's comprehensive tracking report. At least 142 activist groups across 24 states are actively organizing against data center construction.

The Funding Pipeline: Money flows from major left-leaning foundations (Ford Foundation, Open Society Foundations, MacArthur Foundation, Hewlett Foundation) through national nonprofit intermediaries (MediaJustice, Climate Justice Alliance, NAACP, Public Citizen) down to local organizers (Southwest Workers Union, PODER, ad hoc community Facebook groups). MacArthur alone has given MediaJustice \$2.03 million since 2020.

The Framing: The opposition frames data centers as environmental justice and racial equity issues — not merely NIMBY concerns. This framing gives their arguments moral authority and media appeal that traditional anti-development rhetoric lacks.

The Bipartisan Threat: This is not a left-vs-right issue. Data Center Watch found that 55% of elected officials who have taken public positions against data centers are Republicans and 45% are Democrats. In Texas, Republican Senate District 22 candidate Rena Schroeder has made opposition to data centers the centerpiece of her campaign. The Texas State Republican Executive Committee passed a near-unanimous resolution calling for rigorous impact assessments before data center approval.

The Texas Escalation: Texas is the #2 data center state behind Virginia and is rapidly becoming the primary battleground. A "Data Center Rebellion Convening" was held in San Antonio in March 2026, organized by Public Citizen, Climate Justice Alliance, Southwest Workers Union, and Texas Youth Power Alliance. Clayton Tucker, secretary of the Texas Farmers Union and candidate for Texas Agriculture Commissioner, is calling for a full statewide moratorium on data centers. Local opposition groups (Stop the Waco Data Centers, Halt Taylor Data Centers Coalition, Protect the Paluxy Valley) are multiplying rapidly.

Section 1: The Opposition Network — Key Organizations

The data center opposition ecosystem operates at three tiers: national organizations that set narrative and provide resources, regional intermediaries that coordinate campaigns, and local grassroots groups that execute on-the-ground actions. Below is a profile of each major player.

Tier 1: National Organizations

1. NAACP — “Stop Dirty Data Centers” Campaign

What They Do: The NAACP’s Center for Environmental and Climate Justice has made data center opposition a flagship campaign. They released the “Frontline Framework,” the nation’s first environmental-justice-focused data center principles. In January 2026 at CES, they released a “2026 Playbook” for communities to fight data center buildouts. They have filed notice of intent to sue xAI over its Memphis, TN operations.

Key Resources They Provide: Community Benefit Agreement templates, Cost Recovery Support Agreement templates, a “How to Negotiate” guide, a community reporting portal for tracking new proposed data centers, and a “Fact or Fiction” fact sheet designed to debunk data center industry claims.

Why They Matter: The NAACP brand carries enormous institutional credibility and media reach. Their framing of data centers as a civil rights and racial justice issue gives the opposition moral authority that generic NIMBY arguments lack. They have local chapters in every state, giving them immediate infrastructure to activate in any community.

2. MediaJustice

What They Do: MediaJustice published “The People Say No: Resisting Data Centers in the South” (September 2025), which they describe as the first comprehensive regional analysis of data centers in the South. It includes case studies from Louisiana, Mississippi, Tennessee, Georgia, and South Carolina. They also released an “Organizer Toolkit” with activities and resources for community opposition.

Funding (Documented): MacArthur Foundation has provided \$2.03 million in grants to MediaJustice from 2020–2024, including a \$750,000 three-year general support grant in 2024. Their mission focuses on building grassroots movements around media and technology justice.

Why They Matter: MediaJustice provides the professional production layer — toolkits, reports, media campaigns — that local groups lack the capacity to create themselves. They function as the opposition’s content engine.

3. Climate Justice Alliance (CJA)

What They Do: CJA is the connective tissue of the opposition network. They convene member organizations, run the “Data Centers and AI” policy campaign (listed on their website alongside Energy Democracy and Food Sovereignty), and co-organized the San Antonio “Data Center Rebellion Convening” in March 2026.

Membership: CJA’s member network includes Texas-based organizations Southwest Workers Union (SWU), PODER (People Organized in Defense of Earth and Her Resources), and Texas

Environmental Justice Advocacy Services (TEJAS). SWU has approximately 3,000 members in San Antonio.

Funding Philosophy: CJA's own funders page states that only 1.3% of climate philanthropy dollars go to environmental justice organizations, and they are actively lobbying to redirect more. They operate a "Funders Circle" that recruits foundations to shift capital toward grassroots organizing. Their "Four Pathways" framework is designed to channel money from national foundations to local groups.

4. Public Citizen

What They Do: Public Citizen co-organized the San Antonio Data Center Rebellion Convening with CJA and SWU. They provide policy analysis, legislative advocacy, and litigation capacity. Their involvement signals that the data center issue is being elevated from a local NIMBY concern to a national policy battle.

Tier 2: Texas-Specific Organizations

5. Southwest Workers Union (SWU)

Based In: San Antonio, TX. Approximately 3,000 members.

What They Do: SWU runs the Climate Justice San Antonio (CJSA) meetings, hosted the Data Center Rebellion Convening at their offices, and actively organizes against the 50+ data centers in San Antonio (concentrated in District 6). Their blog post on the convening directly connects data centers to "the military industrial complex, surveillance state," and says "all systems of oppression are intertwined."

Why They Matter: SWU is the primary boots-on-the-ground organizing force in San Antonio. Their ability to turn out 60+ organizers for a two-day convening demonstrates real mobilization capacity.

6. Clayton Tucker / Texas Farmers Union

Who: Clayton Tucker is the secretary of the Texas Farmers Union (TFU) and is running for Texas Agriculture Commissioner on a platform that centers opposition to data centers. He has pledged that on "Day 1" of the job, he would issue "Ag Impact Studies" to stop data center construction.

Key Claims: Tucker claims data centers caused electricity prices to rise by 70% in some areas, that they are "waterhogs," that they produce no real long-term jobs, and that the industry is "lying to Americans all across our country." He has called for a full moratorium on data centers in Texas.

Why He Matters: Tucker is elevating data center opposition from community-level organizing to a statewide political campaign issue. His platform explicitly lists requirements for a data center to be "responsible," including unionized labor, fair taxes, no use of prime farmland, and no automation of jobs.

7. Ad Hoc Local Groups

Rapidly forming community groups include Stop the Waco Data Centers, Halt Taylor Data Centers Coalition, Protect the Paluxy Valley, and others. These groups typically organize via Facebook, petition campaigns, and packing City Council meetings. They are the first line of opposition that developers encounter and often are the catalyst for formal organizational involvement.

Political Amplification

Rena Schroeder (R): Republican candidate for Texas Senate District 22, which covers McLennan, Bosque, and Hill Counties — all with contentious data center developments. She has made opposition to data centers the centerpiece of her campaign. This is a critical signal that opposition has crossed partisan lines in Texas.

Texas Republican Executive Committee: In February 2026, the SREC passed a near-unanimous resolution calling for rigorous independent assessments of proposed data center projects before final approval, including a pause on “open loop” data centers that consume the most water.

San Antonio City Council: Councilman Ric Galvan (District 6) authored a Council Consideration Request for more information on hyperscale data centers, co-signed by four other council members.

Section 2: Follow the Money

The opposition to data centers is supported by a professional funding infrastructure. While grassroots groups may appear organic, the national organizations providing their toolkits, legal support, and strategic coordination are funded by some of the largest progressive foundations in the United States.

Documented Funding Flows

Recipient	Amount	Source	Purpose/Notes
MediaJustice	\$750,000	MacArthur (2024)	3-year general support for grassroots base-building and tech justice advocacy
MediaJustice	\$400,000	MacArthur (2022)	2-year general support for network expansion and anti-disinfo campaigning
MediaJustice	\$400,000	MacArthur (2020)	Equitable Recovery program, election resilience for communities of color
MediaJustice	\$400,000	MacArthur (2020)	Pressuring tech cos on civil rights; media justice network building
MediaJustice	\$50,000	MacArthur (2023)	Multimedia project on working-class organizing history in Chicago
MediaJustice	\$30,000	MacArthur (2024)	Take Back Tech conference in Chicago
CJA Network	Est. millions	Ford, Hewlett, Open Society	General support, Just Transition campaigns, grassroots capacity building
NAACP ECJ	Undisclosed	Foundation support	Stop Dirty Data Centers campaign, Frontline Framework, litigation (xAI suit)
Public Citizen	Est. millions	Multiple foundations	Policy analysis, convening, data center regulatory advocacy

The Funding Architecture

The money flows through a three-tier structure designed to maximize reach and maintain credibility:

Tier 1 — Foundation Funders: Ford Foundation (\$17.5B endowment), Open Society Foundations, MacArthur Foundation, and William and Flora Hewlett Foundation provide multi-million dollar, multi-year unrestricted grants to national intermediaries. These foundations explicitly fund “environmental justice,” “climate justice,” and “technology accountability” as named programs. The Ford Foundation’s BUILD program alone committed \$2 billion to social justice nonprofits globally before being retired in 2025.

Tier 2 — National Nonprofits: MediaJustice, Climate Justice Alliance, Public Citizen, and the NAACP receive foundation funding and transform it into professional-grade outputs: research reports, organizer toolkits, CBA templates, media campaigns, legal filings, and convening infrastructure. CJA’s “Four Pathways” framework is an explicit strategy document for moving philanthropic capital to grassroots organizations.

Tier 3 — Local Organizers: Southwest Workers Union, PODER, Texas Environmental Justice Advocacy Services, Texas Youth Power Alliance, and ad hoc community groups (Stop the Waco Data Centers, Halt Taylor Data Centers Coalition) receive resources, training, toolkits, and convening support from Tier 2 organizations. CJA's own reporting indicates that only 1.3% of climate philanthropy reaches grassroots organizations, and they are actively lobbying to increase that share.

The Bottom Line: This is not a spontaneous community uprising. It is a coordinated, well-funded campaign with professional infrastructure, legal capacity, and a deliberate strategy to weaponize local land-use processes against data center development. The framing as “environmental justice” makes it difficult to dismiss and gives it media credibility that traditional anti-development opposition lacks.

Section 3: Opposition Arguments & Recommended Retorts

Below is every major argument the opposition deploys, extracted from their own publications, websites, and public statements, paired with evidence-based counter-messaging. These retorts are designed for use in public hearings, media interviews, community meetings, and written communications.

3.1 Water Consumption

Opposition Argument	Recommended Response
THEIR CLAIM: Data centers are “waterhogs” that will drain local aquifers and drive up water bills. A mid-size data center uses 300,000 gallons per day — equivalent to 1,000 homes.	YOUR RETORT: Modern data centers use closed-loop and air-cooling systems that reduce water use by 80–95% compared to older designs. Google, Microsoft, and Meta have all committed to being water-positive by 2030, meaning they will replenish more water than they consume. Compare: a single 18-hole golf course uses 312,000 gallons per day. A data center on the same acreage generates billions in economic value. Moreover, leading operators invest in watershed restoration, aquifer recharge, and municipal water infrastructure as part of their host community agreements.
THEIR CLAIM: Even “closed loop” systems use a tremendous amount of water. Tucker claims operators have been “lying to Americans” about usage.	YOUR RETORT: Water consumption data is publicly reported by all major hyperscalers in their annual sustainability reports. Google’s 2024 Environmental Report disclosed water usage for every campus. The claim that the industry is “hiding” data doesn’t hold up — the question is whether communities are choosing to look at publicly available information or relying on opposition talking points.

3.2 Energy and Grid Strain

Opposition Argument	Recommended Response
THEIR CLAIM: Data centers will consume 12% of all U.S. electricity by 2030 and will drive up electricity prices for residential customers. Tucker claims prices rose 70% in some areas.	YOUR RETORT: ERCOT and major grid operators require large loads to secure their own generation capacity or purchase behind-the-meter power. Texas SB 6 (2025) specifically gives ERCOT authority to cut power to large facilities during emergencies. Data centers in ERCOT territory are increasingly building their own solar, wind, and natural gas generation, adding net new capacity to the grid rather than drawing from it. The 70% price claim needs context — electricity costs are driven by fuel markets, grid investment, and weather events, not any single customer class.
THEIR CLAIM: Diesel backup generators cause massive pollution. SWU calls them a	YOUR RETORT: Backup generators run only during grid outages, typically less than 100 hours per year, and

major health threat.	are required by code for any critical infrastructure (hospitals, water treatment plants, etc.). New EPA Tier 4 standards have reduced diesel particulate emissions by 90%+. Leading operators are transitioning to battery storage, natural gas, and hydrogen fuel cells as backup, making this a rapidly diminishing concern.
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3.3 Jobs and Economic Impact

Opposition Argument	Recommended Response
THEIR CLAIM: Data centers don't create long-term jobs. NAACP's "Fact or Fiction" sheet asks if data centers are "creating long-term jobs." Tucker says they are "net negative for job creation" because automation destroys more jobs than are created.	YOUR RETORT: A typical hyperscale data center employs 30–50 full-time operations staff and generates 1,000–3,000 construction jobs over 2–3 years. But the bigger story is the ecosystem effect: data centers anchor tech clusters that attract software companies, managed service providers, fiber providers, and specialized contractors. Northern Virginia's data center corridor supports 50,000+ jobs across the ecosystem. The AI services these centers enable are creating entirely new job categories and industries.
THEIR CLAIM: Tax abatements mean communities don't actually benefit financially. They're getting "shorted."	YOUR RETORT: Even with abatements, a single hyperscale campus typically generates \$10–50 million in annual tax revenue to its host county, because the assessed value of a \$1B+ facility is enormous even at reduced rates. The NAACP's own CBA template implicitly acknowledges this by negotiating for community benefits — which means the economic pie exists. The question is fair distribution, not whether there is value. Developers should proactively propose robust CBAs, host community funds, and infrastructure investments before opposition groups set the terms.

3.4 Environmental Justice and Racial Equity

Opposition Argument	Recommended Response
THEIR CLAIM: Data centers are being sited in Black and Brown communities, repeating the pattern of environmental racism. The NAACP says this "feels painfully familiar."	YOUR RETORT: The data center industry should take this concern seriously and lead with transparency. Best practice is to publish environmental impact data before permitting, conduct third-party health impact assessments, and offer legally binding community benefit agreements with enforceable environmental protections. The way to counter this narrative is not to dismiss it — it's to demonstrate that data center development is the cleanest, quietest, and most economically productive industrial land use available, and to back that up with data.
THEIR CLAIM: SWU and CJA connect data centers to "the military industrial complex, surveillance state," and ICE raids. They	YOUR RETORT: This ideological framing conflates infrastructure with politics. Every website, streaming service, telemedicine platform, online school, and

frame opposition as an anti-oppression fight.	small business e-commerce site depends on data center infrastructure. Opposing data centers on the basis of what they might compute is like opposing roads because they might carry trucks to places you don't like. Focus the conversation on concrete local impacts — water, power, noise, taxes — not abstract political arguments.
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3.5 Agricultural Land and Rural Character

Opposition Argument	Recommended Response
THEIR CLAIM: Tucker says data centers should not be placed on prime farmland. Texas Ag Commissioner Sid Miller supports “Agriculture Freedom Zones.”	YOUR RETORT: Responsible siting is a legitimate concern. Industry best practice is to prioritize brownfield sites, existing industrial parks, and land without active agricultural use. However, the idea that data centers convert more agricultural land than residential subdivision, solar farms, or oil and gas development is not supported by the data. A data center's physical footprint is dramatically smaller per dollar of economic output than almost any other industrial use.
THEIR CLAIM: Data centers produce a low-frequency hum that causes health issues for five or more miles. Tucker cites risks to children and the elderly.	YOUR RETORT: Noise from data centers is primarily generated by cooling systems and is governed by local noise ordinances. Modern designs achieve 50–60 dB at the property line — comparable to a quiet conversation. Claims of health effects from “low-frequency vibration” traveling five miles lack peer-reviewed scientific support. Developers should proactively commission independent acoustic assessments and share them publicly.

3.6 Transparency and Community Process

Opposition Argument	Recommended Response
THEIR CLAIM: Developers operate behind NDAs and don't disclose water, power, or environmental impacts until it's too late for the community to respond.	YOUR RETORT: This is the single most damaging criticism because it is often true. The industry's standard practice of requiring NDAs and disclosing minimal information during permitting processes feeds opposition narratives and creates distrust. The recommended counter-strategy is radical transparency: proactively publish projected water and power usage, commission and share independent environmental assessments, hold community open houses before filing permits, and propose robust CBAs with enforceable terms. The opposition wins when developers appear secretive. Take that weapon away.

Section 4: Strategic Recommendations

Based on the opposition's documented playbook, funding structure, and messaging, the following recommendations are designed to change the dynamic from reactive defense to proactive engagement.

4.1 Lead with Transparency Before You're Forced Into It

The opposition's most effective weapon is the perception that developers are hiding information behind NDAs and secretive permitting processes. Neutralize this by publishing environmental and economic impact data proactively, before activists request it. Commission third-party assessments and release them publicly. The goal is to own the narrative before the opposition frames it.

4.2 Propose Community Benefit Agreements First

The NAACP has already published CBA templates. If developers wait for communities to demand CBAs, they will negotiate from a position of weakness using the NAACP's terms. Instead, developers should arrive at the first community meeting with a draft CBA that includes infrastructure investments, utility rate protections, local hiring commitments, and environmental monitoring provisions. Setting the initial terms of negotiation is critical.

4.3 Inoculate Republican Officials Against Partisan Crossover

The bipartisan nature of this opposition is its most strategically dangerous feature. When Republican officials like Rena Schroeder and the Texas State Republican Executive Committee adopt anti-data-center positions, it removes the political safety net that pro-business candidates typically provide. Engagement with Republican officials must emphasize national security implications of AI infrastructure, energy independence, property rights of willing sellers, and the economic multiplier effects of data center investment — all within a conservative values framework.

4.4 Disaggregate the Coalition

The opposition's strength is in its coalition — the alliance between environmental justice groups, farmers, NIMBY homeowners, and fiscal conservatives who oppose tax abatements. These groups have fundamentally different concerns. Environmental justice organizations want equitable siting and community benefits. Farmers want water protection. Homeowners want noise and property-value protection. Fiscal conservatives want fair taxation. A one-size-fits-all response strengthens the coalition. Tailored responses to each group's specific concerns can split it.

4.5 Compete on the Moral High Ground

The NAACP and MediaJustice have framed data center opposition as a moral cause — environmental justice, racial equity, community self-determination. The data center industry has countered almost exclusively with economic arguments (jobs, tax revenue). Economic arguments do not beat moral arguments. The industry needs to articulate its own moral case: data centers enable telemedicine, remote education, small business e-commerce, disaster response, medical research,

and climate modeling. The infrastructure opposition groups want to block is the same infrastructure that enables the digital economy lifting communities out of poverty.

4.6 Monitor and Map the Opposition in Real Time

Data Center Watch's report is the most comprehensive public mapping of opposition to date. Developers should invest in ongoing monitoring of local Facebook groups, petition platforms (Change.org), city council agendas, and state legislative filings. Early detection of organized opposition — before it reaches the Planning Commission hearing stage — allows proactive engagement instead of reactive crisis management.

Appendix: Source URLs & Key Documents

Primary Sources Researched

MediaJustice, “The People Say No: Resisting Data Centers in the South” (September 2025):
mediajustice.org/resource/the-people-say-no-report/

Southwest Workers Union, “Data Center Rebellion Convening 2026” (March 2026):
swunion.org/blog/data-center-rebellion-convening-2026

Clayton Tucker for TX Ag Commissioner, “Stop AI Centers”: claytontuckertx.com/stop_ai_centers

NAACP, “Stop Dirty Data Centers” Campaign Page: naacp.org/campaigns/stop-dirty-data-centers

MacArthur Foundation Grant Record for MediaJustice: macfound.org/grantee/center-for-media-justice-10115159/

Climate Justice Alliance, Funders & Donors Page: climatejusticealliance.org/funders/

Data Center Watch Report (\$64B Blocked/Delayed): datacenterwatch.org/report

Additional Sources

Texas Tribune, “Texans are demanding their local governments push pause on data centers” (February 2026)

Reporting Texas, “Texans Demand Special Legislative Session for Data Center Debate” (February 2026)

Taylor Press, “In Taylor, critics rally against data centers” (March 2026)

NAACP, “2026 Recommendations for Protecting Frontline Communities” (January 2026)

Nonprofit Quarterly, “How the NAACP Is Stopping Dirty Data” (March 2026)

Data Center Watch full database of 142 activist groups across 24 states

This report was compiled from publicly available sources including organizational websites, grant databases, news reporting, and public government filings. All claims and characterizations are based on the opposition organizations' own published materials, statements, and documented activities.